

Acrylic Painting Techniques Vol. 1

15 essential acrylic techniques every painter should know.

Acrylic paint is the most versatile medium available to contemporary painters. It can be diluted to the transparency of watercolor. It can be built up to the thick impasto texture of oil paint. It dries fast, it is water-soluble while wet, it adheres to almost any surface, and it does not yellow or crack over time the way oil paint can. Despite these advantages, many painters only ever scratch the surface of what acrylics can do. This guide covers fifteen essential techniques that will fundamentally change how you use this extraordinary medium.

The guide is organized so that each technique builds on the one before it. The first five techniques are fundamental: flat color application, blending wet-on-wet, dry brushing, glazing, and scumbling. These form the backbone of most acrylic painting approaches and understanding them deeply will make every subsequent technique easier to grasp. Each technique is demonstrated on a small six-inch square panel with full step-by-step photographs and detailed written instructions covering the brush type, paint consistency, and application pressure required.

Impasto is given its own extended chapter because it represents such a departure from conventional flat painting. Working with thick paint directly from the tube or mixed with a heavy gel medium opens up a completely different relationship with the paint surface. Marks become physical objects rather than flat shapes. Light rakes across ridges and peaks, creating shadows that change throughout the day as the light source moves. You will learn how to use palette knives, stiff hog hair brushes, and found objects to create a range of impasto textures.

Sgraffito is one of the most exciting techniques in this guide and one of the least known among beginning painters. By scratching through a wet layer of paint to reveal the dry layer beneath, you can create textures and marks that are simply impossible to achieve with a brush. The guide covers sgraffito with both tools and improvised objects, showing how to use this technique to suggest texture in wood, stone, fabric, and foliage.

The advanced techniques in the latter half of the guide include pouring, resist methods, stamping, and texture paste application. Pouring has become enormously popular in recent years, and while much of what you see online relies on expensive specialty mediums, this guide shows you how to achieve beautiful poured effects with standard acrylics and a few inexpensive additives. The resist chapter covers masking fluid, wax resist, and tape masking, showing how to preserve white areas and create hard edges that would be difficult to achieve by painting negatively.

The guide ends with three complete painting demonstrations that each combine multiple techniques from throughout the book. The first is a landscape that uses wet-on-wet blending, dry brushing, and palette knife work for the foreground texture. The second is an abstract piece that uses pouring, sgraffito, and stamping. The third is a still life that uses glazing and scumbling to build luminous color through layering. Each demonstration is fully photographed at every stage so you can follow the entire process from blank canvas to finished painting.